

China Completed in 30 Years a Road That Took the Developed Countries 300 — Is It Something to Be Proud Of?

Zhihu

In fact, the diffusion of technologies and modes of production is the norm throughout the history of Homo sapiens; globalisation has only accelerated it. But the framing of this question is itself not quite accurate.

First, the industrial level of the People's Republic of China was not 300 years behind the West. Although after 1500 the wealth of Western Europe gradually overtook that of both the West and the developed regions of the non-West (China, India, Japan), the marked divergence in productive forces really began only with the Industrial Revolution (in the second half of the eighteenth century). The productivity of large-scale machine industry far exceeded that of handicrafts, and the widespread application of capital-driven science produced technological revolutions at every level of society. By the second half of the nineteenth century, a huge generational gap had opened between the military industries of the West and those of non-Western countries: had they fought with their respective military technologies, the latter would have been massacred one-sidedly.

Hence all the ancient civilisations that had not yet been fully colonised were compelled to reform in order to survive — the Meiji Restoration in Japan, the Self-Strengthening Movement in China — learning Western technology, industry, and even institutions. Although only Japan succeeded among these movements, China was not without gains. In the late Qing, China already possessed a certain industrial capacity — the Hanyang-made arms, for instance. Under the Republic, industrial capacity developed further. In 1949, China's steel output was a little over 100,000 tonnes, surpassing Britain's level of around 1850; its pig iron output was 250,000 tonnes, comparable to Britain's level of 1806; its coal output exceeded 30 million tonnes, roughly Britain's level of 1840. In overall industrial strength, China in 1949 stood at the level of the early First Industrial Revolution — about 130 years behind Britain. In the hundred years after 1840, the gap had actually widened, from 90 years to 130. Even so, since China had already begun the First Industrial Revolution and possessed a certain industrial base, a 1949 China placed back in 1840 would, by virtue of its own industrial strength, have been able to resist British aggression.

Second, New China's catch-up was not accomplished within 30 years.

The catch-up after the founding of New China came in two stages: 1949–1978, and 1979 through the 2020s.

From 1949 to 1978, China — through self-reliance, plus Soviet assistance in the early period — basically completed the First and Second Industrial Revolutions: it mechanised light industry and built up the core industries of the Second Industrial Revolution, such as oil refining, electric power, and the internal combustion engine. In 1978, China's electricity generation was over 200 billion kilowatt-hours, comparable to the United States of the 1940s. Steel output reached over 30 million tonnes, comparable to the United States of the latter half of the 1930s. Coal output in 1978 reached 600 million tonnes, exceeding the US level of 1950. Crude oil output was 100 million tonnes, roughly the US level of the 1930s, with refining capacity to match. In 1978, China produced about 150,000 automobiles — comparable to the United States of about 1910, but exceeding the output of the Japanese Empire of 1940. On the whole, by 1978 China's industrial level lagged behind the most advanced countries by about 50 years. In the first thirty years of New China, some 80 years of the gap were closed; about 50 years remained against the West. Had the China of 1978 been placed in the Second World War, even without post-war technology, it could have defeated Japan with ease on its own strength.

After 1978, as China integrated into the American-led globalised order, capital goods and technology poured into the country in vast quantities. China on the one hand accelerated the spread of First and Second Industrial Revolution technology across the whole country, and on the other introduced Western technology to catch up in the Third Industrial Revolution. By around 2018, almost every major industrial indicator had become the world's first. In the second stage of New China, the final gap of about 50 years was closed over some 40 years.

Third, the impression many people have of "30 years catching up with 300" stems mainly from the fact that most Chinese people entered the cities only in the last 30 years.

After 1992, China's urbanisation rate was under 30%, with the vast majority of the population living in the countryside. Thirty years later, in 2022, China's urbanisation had exceeded 60%, and most of those born after 1980 had moved to the cities. To the older among them, the China of 30 years ago may indeed have seemed 300 years behind the West: their childhood in the 1980s was little different from the life of a Qing-dynasty peasant smallholder of 1720 — save for electric light. Farming was still done with hoes and oxen; relatives visited each other on foot across a dozen kilometres; news travelled by letter. And the previous generation had lived through nationwide famine in the 1960s — China truly shook off hunger only in the 1970s, once fertiliser output had risen. It is no wonder the people hold such ideas.

Finally, if you look at the industrial data of Vietnam, Indonesia, India, Turkey, Egypt, the UAE, Saudi Arabia, and other countries, you will see that over the last 30 years their catch-up has been very rapid

as well. In the age of globalisation, capital flows across the world: a country with natural resources, human resources, the necessary infrastructure, and — for whatever reason — a government committed to modernisation can attract all the factors of production to combine within it. Hence the oil states, being rich, can simply buy and buy, bringing in Indian and Pakistani labour to build industrial systems. Other countries that passed through nationalism after the Second World War, having more or less built basic industries and infrastructure, and blessed with abundant labour, can likewise attract capital and accelerate their development. We live in an era of rapid industrialisation proceeding wave after wave across the whole globe; the so-called "30 years catching up with 300" will be felt by the peoples of every Third World country, and hotly debated on their own equivalents of Zhihu.

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